

Project report-out & lessons learned

Team name & members:

Group D: Bushra Alkhateeb, Abrianna Primavera, Parsa Mozouni and Chimeremeze Richmond

Project sponsor:

Dr. Tim Maciag (ENSE 271 Professor)

Business need/opportunity

“As part of course-based learning activities, to work alongside the Community Foundation, OSI-CAN Saskatchewan, and Reach Autism Learning in exploring new and innovative web designs that allow these charities to efficiently and effectively communicate their organizations mission/vision/values, their programming/services, and calls to action. High-level guidelines, principles, constraints, & assumptions include:

- Design approach: Design Thinking (Agile)/Fast Feedback Cycle
- License: Creative Commons Share & Share Alike (CC BY-SA 4.0)
- Technology/Programming environment: StoriesOnBoard (Tim/Adam will be creating user accounts), Figma, WordPress, Local by Flywheel, GitHub (public repository required)

Initial design notes o Basic website criteria:

- Home page: Engaging and inviting. Place to highlight relevant and timely content
- Contact Page: Includes various ways to engage with the charity (phone number, email, address, social medias, etc.)
- Call to Action Page: Must have a clear call to action (to donate, or engage in other ways applicable)
- About Page: Who the charity is, their mission/vision/values, other information about the charity (how they started, who makes up their staff/board, etc.)
- Programs/Services: Should be able to communicate what programs/services the charity provides to the public.

Current website pain points to solve: Make it clear that OSI-CAN support extends beyond Occupational PTSD, it also includes trauma not related to a person's employment. Explore ways to organize and display their resources. Make sure to still differentiate OSI-CAN resources from additional resources. Make it easy to manage from a website maintenance standpoint. Ways to effectively communicate programs/targeted information.

Reflections on Project Planning, Execution, and Closing

NorthStar and Carryover Customers

Northstar:

Individuals who struggle with PTSD and Occupational Stress.

Carryover:

OSI-CAN leaders, donors, volunteers, family members of those with PTSD and/or an OSI

Assumptions and Constraints

When we began working with WordPress we had a feeling that we would face constraints, particularly the physical limitations of WordPress editor. And as expected, we noticed that some of the features we wanted to add were not available in the website builder. Nevertheless, we were able to overcome them. For example, in our prototype, we had planned on adding online forms in the form of modular windows, but this option wasn't available. Due to this, we resorted to creating forms using entire web pages. Although this approach is different from what we originally planned, it appears to have enabled the forms to be more legible.

Key Findings from Affinity Diagramming and Empathy Mapping

Explained below are the important information and conclusions obtained from completing an affinity diagram, as well as multiple empathy maps.

Affinity Diagraming

Our affinity diagram ended up having four separate groups: target demographic, features, design, and user navigation. They each had beneath them six, one, ten, and twelve notes, respectively. Through this activity, we ended up finding what was most important for the redesign of the OSI-CAN website, as well as what our main focuses should be while creating our new design.

The process helped us realize the importance of the site reaching its target demographic. They need to not get turned away, by neither the design of the site nor the feeling that they do not fit its target audience. The design needs to make them feel included, welcome, and supported.

Another finding was that the site did not need many additional features. It just needed the information on it to be properly organized, for the navigation to be more user-friendly, and for the design to be less overwhelming. This was concluded from the number of notes within each group. If a group had more notes it was likely more important to focus on.

Found within the larger groups were our main design focuses. These included the colours of the site, which Mr. Brown stated should be red and blue, an updated and reorganized resources page, and a simple yet appealing look and navigation.

Empathy Mapping

The main finding through this was just how many people might come across or seek this site, and all for completely different reasons. They may be an OSI-CAN leader providing aid and resources, they may be someone who is seeking support, or even someone who is interested in donating to or volunteering for the charity. All these different users have their own needs, wants, and goals for the site.

Found from the empathy map of the site owners, were the main goals of OSI-CAN, what the charity stands to accomplish, and what is important to them. The people running the site wish to aid and support those suffering from occupation related mental health issues.

The donor and volunteer maps helped us to find the site's potential barriers to donate and volunteer. These barriers included difficult to locate pages, overwhelming webpage design, and potentially not being given sufficient reason to donate or volunteer.

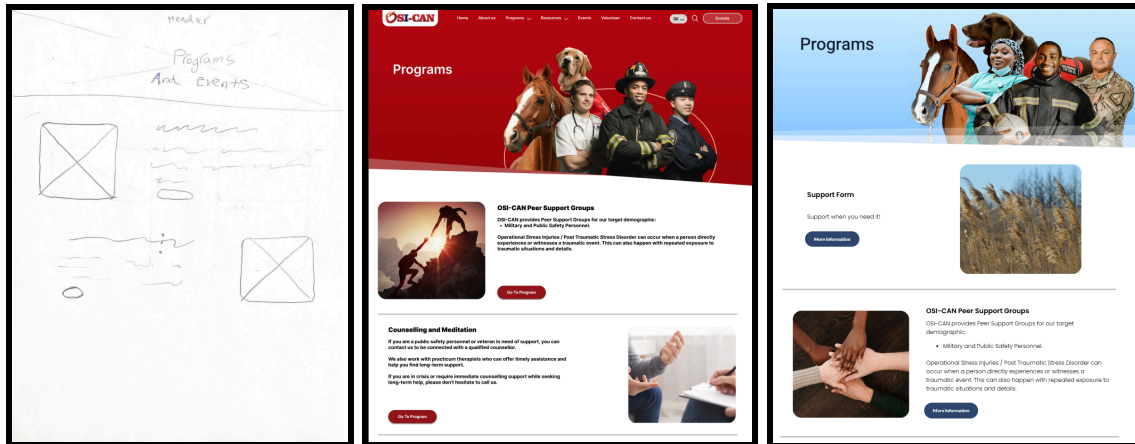
For the people seeking support, the empathy map helped us imagine what headspace someone may be in when seeking/ visiting the site and what their goals would be. They would likely appreciate simplicity and might not be in the mood to extensively search for their desired information. Therefore, everything should be easily accessible for them.

User Story Map

For our story maps, initially as a group we all sat together and agreed on a set user story map that serves the needs of the user. Things that are present in our design such as, a home page, resource page, and all the other pages while providing the user the ability to navigate, interact and use them was our initial idea. Then as time progressed, we started implementing the user story map into our design the best way possible. We believe that what we produced is a MVP because it is an early version of a product that provides real value and purpose. Our design includes the most essential elements that makes our website usable while providing value. In our design, a user will find things such as a home page, viable information, useful resources and ways to interact and get involved with the project (OSICAN) itself. This is done, by allowing the user to view information about volunteering, signing up and allowing the user to provide donations.

Summary of Prototyping Activities and Usability Evaluation Findings

Below, from left to right, are images of the programs page from our low fidelity prototype, our first high fidelity prototype, and final WordPress solution.



The goal of the first prototyping activity was to create a lo-fi prototype. To begin, each of our group members created their own skeletal web page designs. We then took inspiration from these, to create a final lo-fi prototype. For the second prototyping activity, the goal was to create a more detailed and functional hi-fi prototype. After deciding on a colour scheme and on the elements that would remain consistent throughout the whole site, we each took a page from our final lo-fi design and individually brought it to life in Figma.

During activity two we also conducted a usability evaluation by observing how our customer and classmates interacted with the design and by noting their resulting thoughts. Mr. Brown's key takeaways were that it was simple, that it was easy to navigate and that it was red. This was the biggest finding from the evaluation, since he stated that red can be a triggering colour for the main users of the OSI-CAN site. After hearing this, we changed the main colour of the whole prototype to blue and continued to use this colour for our final solution. It was also pointed out that we did not include an emergency contact line. We added that to the solution, as well. The main findings from our classmates were that we were missing a blog section, that the titles on the about us page looked like buttons, and that a button to the main program page should be added to the individual program pages. The first two were not implemented into the final design. The last point was.

During these two activities, we also kept in mind certain design ideas that we learned in this class. The most prominent in the displayed designs were the Gestalt principles of proximity and enclosure. In each iteration of the programs page, the title, description, photo, and button for each program are all either separated by a greater white space or by horizontal bars. This makes it easier for the user to tell what information is relevant to that specific program. The buttons are also an example of signifiers and of knowledge in the head and in the world. People who regularly use the internet have likely seen and experienced ovals of a contrasting colour, a promise such as "More Info", and that change colour when you hover over them. From experience, they likely know that those are the signifiers of something that can be pressed. This knowledge is reflected in the world of our design. Another idea that we used while planning our project was Nielsen's usability heuristic of aesthetic and minimalist design. Each of our

prototypes and iterations only contain information that we thought was important. No unnecessary images, features, and text that could distract from the page's main focus.

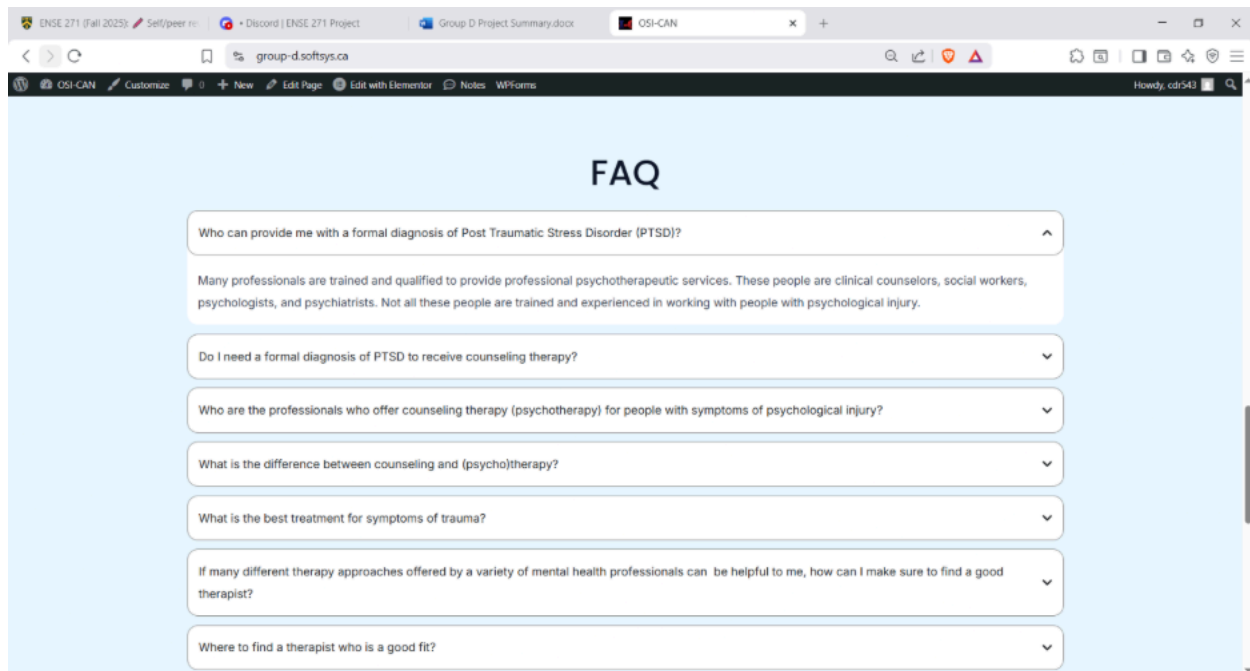
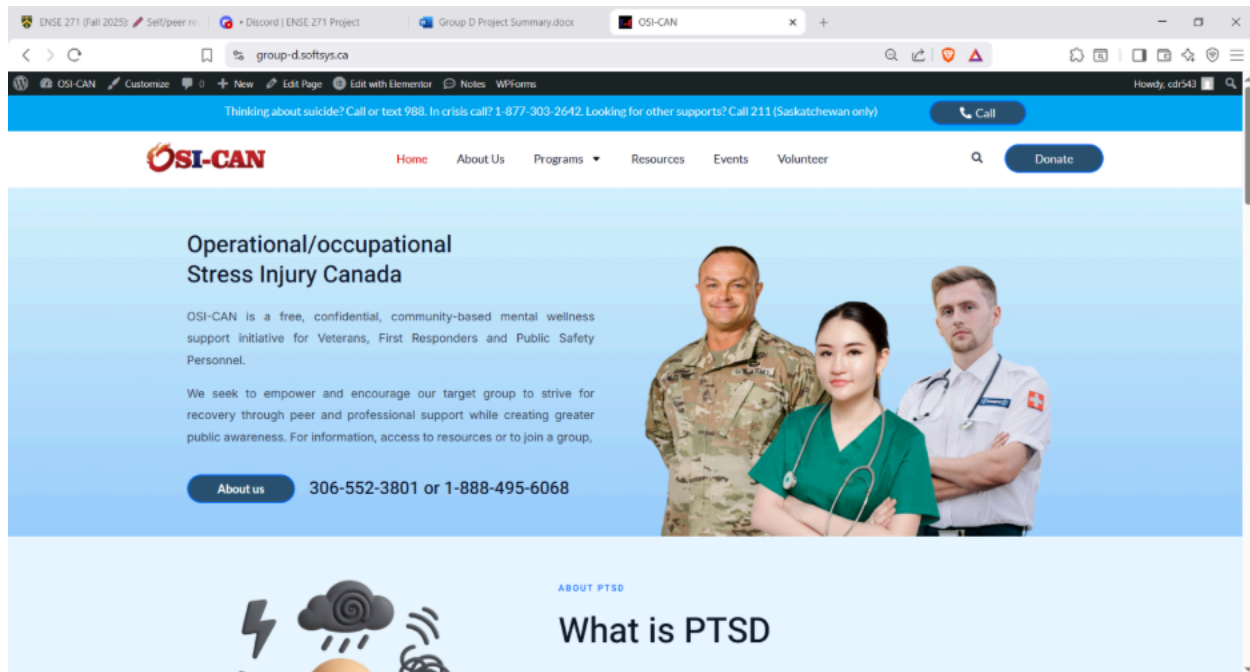
Summary of Final WordPress Solution

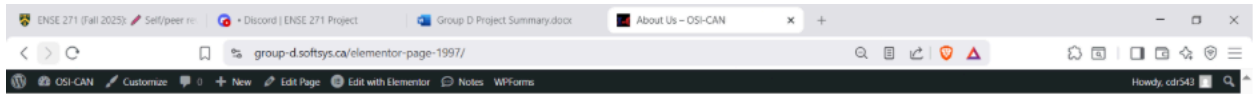
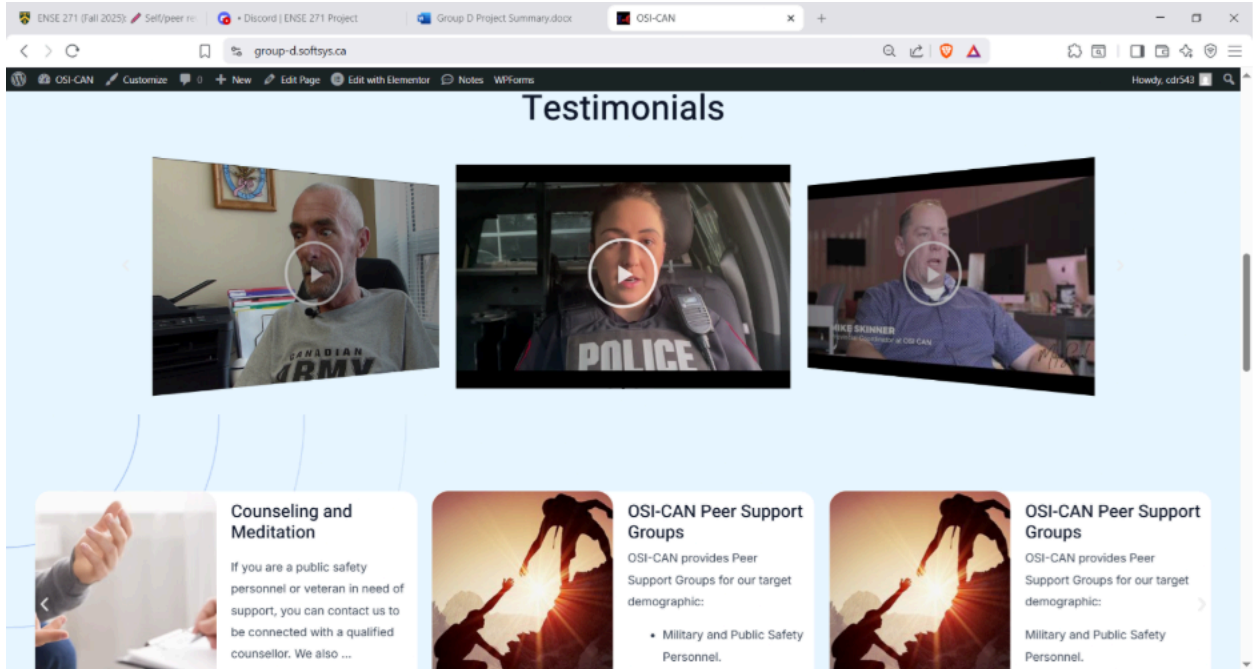
Our final WordPress solution is a modern take on a charity website for OSI-CAN. The site consists of six primary web pages: Home, About Us, Programs, Resources, Events, and Volunteer. The Home page gives a brief introduction to the OSI-CAN program, followed by a definition of PTSD (Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder): the website's target problem. The home page also includes testimonials, an overview of OSI-CAN's programs, and a FAQ section. The About Us page gives an introduction to OSI-CAN's historical background. It also introduces OSI-CAN's mission, target demographic, vision, and values. The Programs page lists OSI-CAN's programs, with each item entailing a brief description of its respective program and a navigation button to its respective web page. Considering the navigation buttons, the Programs page has 8 subpages for each program. The Resources page shows a filterable catalogue of OSI-CAN resources. The events page provides a list of upcoming OSI-CAN events, including their scheduled dates. The final page, the volunteer page, gives an overview of OSI-CAN's volunteer program and directs customers to apply for volunteer opportunities.

Before working with WordPress, our group built high-fidelity prototypes using Figma. When designing the website prototype, we aimed for a less congested and more modern style. Due to this, our design relied heavily on the use of vector shapes and sans-serif font. In addition, we were judicious with our use of images, as we recognized that too much use of images congested the original website and made understanding the site's content that much more difficult. In our prototype design, we also included interactive elements such as site navigation/link buttons, a search bar, a catalogue filter, and online forms. These not only gave the site notable features but also provided customers with certain affordances, such as searching for specific information and jumping through webpages. In our prototype, we also decided to incorporate semantic constraints, utilizing a design structure similar to that of modern websites, so that customers will not experience confusion when visiting. Finally, for our site's aesthetic, we originally decided to go with a red-oriented colour scheme, but this soon changed after our first feedback.

During our customer check-ins, we received some feedback. The most notable being to adjust the colour scheme to ease customers, as our client felt that a red-branded aesthetic would be triggering instead of comforting. In light of this, we went for a light blue colour scheme instead, which pleased our client. Once we finalized our prototype and began working with WordPress, we faced certain physical constraints. For example, in our prototype, we had planned on adding online forms in the form of modular windows, but this option wasn't available. Due to this, we resorted to creating forms using entire web pages. Although this approach is different from what we originally planned, it appears to have enabled the forms to be more legible. In all, we believe that we have designed an effective website for OSI-CAN.

Screenshots:





Where it all started

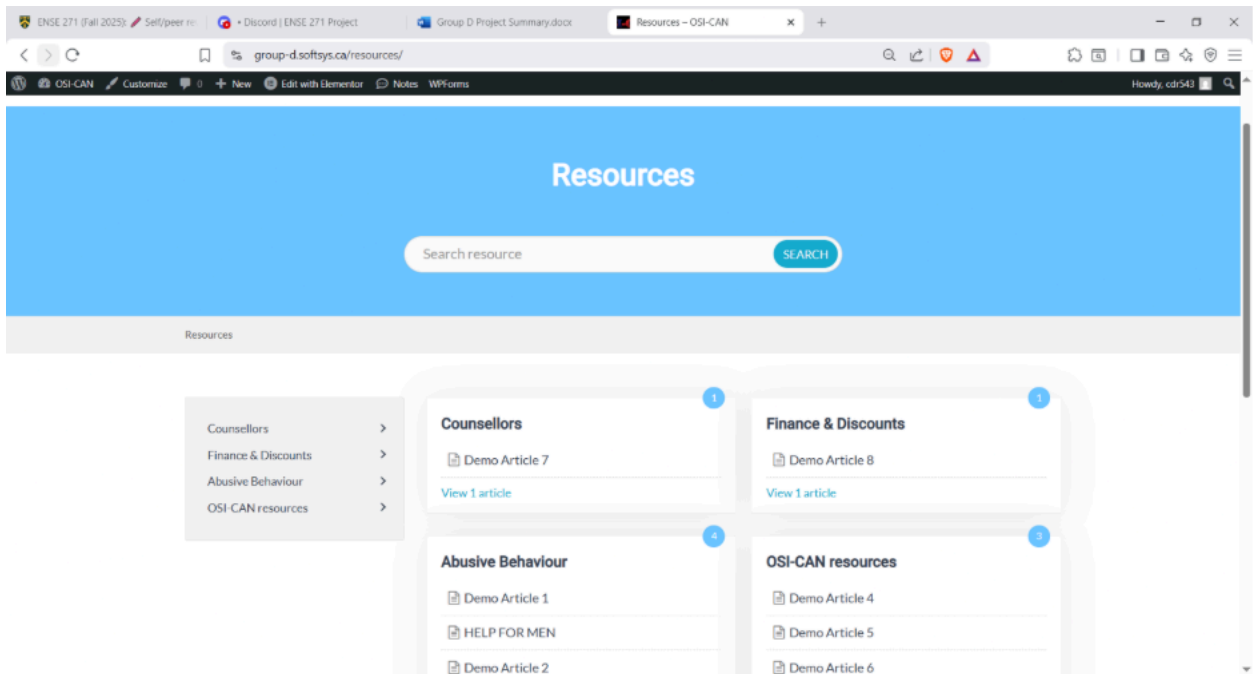
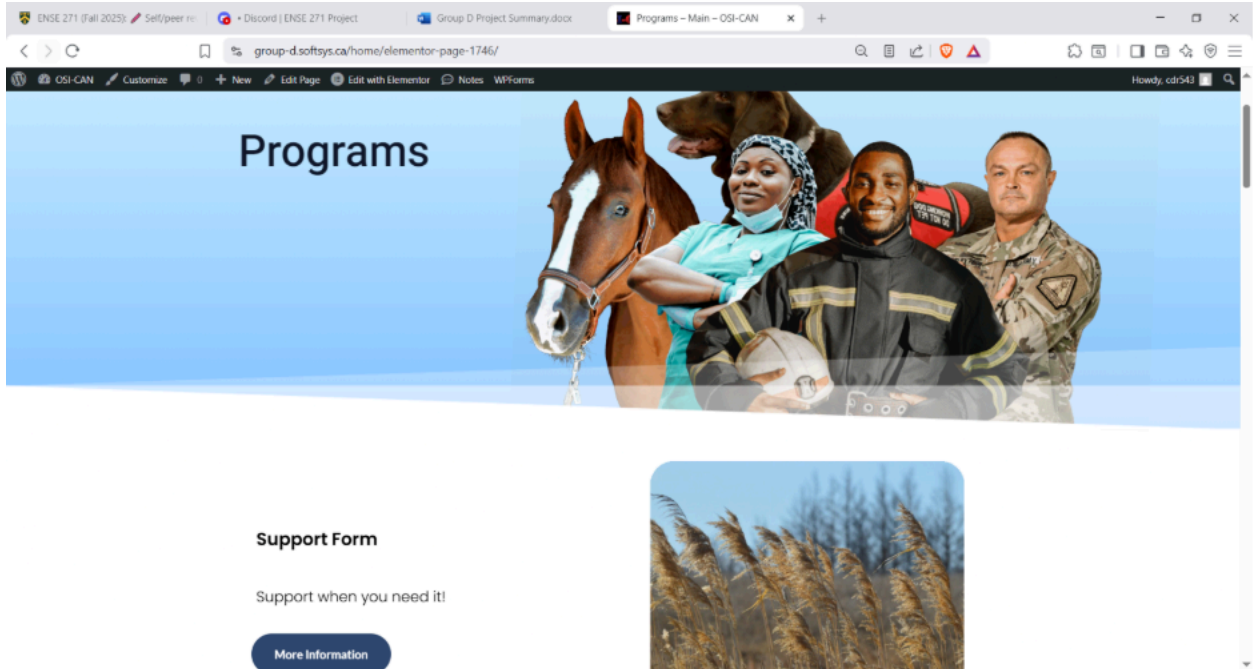
OSI-CAN is an Operational Stress Injury/Post Traumatic Stress Support Initiative.

We were created in January 2016 through a partnership between the Canadian Mental Health Association (SK) and The Royal Canadian Legion (Saskatchewan Command). OSI-CAN has now expanded into covering four provinces: Manitoba, Saskatchewan, Alberta, and British Columbia!

OSI-CAN offers Peer Support Groups (facilitated by trained members with lived experience), Family Support Groups, Financial Assistance with Service Dog acquisition, Equine Therapy programs and Indigenous Sweats led by Indigenous Knowledge Keepers. Our support groups provide a free, safe, confidential, non-judgmental environment where we can talk openly about mental health. No formal diagnosis or referral is required to get help from OSI-CAN!



Our Mission and Demographics



ENSE 271 (Fall 2025)Self/peer re...Discord | ENSE 271 ProjectGroup D Project Summary.docxEvents - OSI-CAN

group-d.softsys.ca/events/

OSI-CANCustomize0NewEdit PageEdit with ElementorNotesWFormsHowdy, cdf543

Events



OSICAN MINI INDY RACE FOR RECOVERY

July

24

An intertaining way to improve PTSD awareness and have some fun at Moose Jaw's Town&Country Hall. We look for donations and sponsorships so that this can be a free event to attend in the



ENSE 271 (Fall 2025)Self/peer re...Discord | ENSE 271 ProjectGroup D Project Summary.docxVolunteer Form - OSI-CAN

group-d.softsys.ca/volunteer-form/

OSI-CANCustomize0NewEdit PageEdit with ElementorNotesWFormsHowdy, cdf543

Volunteer Form

Name *

FirstLast

Email *

Phone Number

Where do you live in Saskatchewan? *

--- Select Choice ---

Are you currently working or retired? Select an option

☐ Working

☐ Retired

☐ Other

What do you do for a living?

Have you experienced operational stress or post traumatic stress lived experience? * *

Reflections on Project Results

Likes and dislikes

As a collective, we believe that we enjoyed working on this project. We liked the fact that we had the chance to meet with our client directly, hearing their comments and taking their suggestions for improvements. As well as, building skills in design, communication and working with new tools. Tackling our way into working with Figma and Wordpress was an interesting experience. It taught us patience, perseverance and creativity. It taught us problem solving when certain things didn't function as we planned, as we had to find alternative solutions most of the time to problems that emerged.

Things that went well during the project

We believe a lot of the decisions we made went well in our project. One of which would be our problem solving skills when it came to miscommunication and decision making. As a collective, we tried to always compromise together for a final solution to problems by communicating our ideas and thoughts with open minds and receiving them with open hearts. The second thing was translating the concepts we learn in class into our design. One of the key concepts that was always at the back of our minds was to design a product that fits the needs of the user not the designer. We knew the importance and high significance of putting ourselves into the shoes of the user instead of thinking about decisions only from a designer's perspective which we believe has been translated well in our design.

Things that did not go well during the project

On the other hand, similar to any project, some things might not go as planned even if we do our utmost to perfect them. In our case, one of the things we sometimes struggled with was trying to plan a good time for everyone for meetings. This is due to the fact that we all had different schedules from each other and that sometimes hindered our opportunities to meet more frequently. Although when planning to meet in person wouldn't work we met online as an alternative.

Translating prototypes into WordPress reality

We believe we were successful to some degree in translating our prototypes to WordPress. Most of the ideas we had planned in our prototypes, the low fidelity and the Figma prototypes, were translated directly into WordPress in the same format. Some of the changes that needed to take place was our "pop up" form for the volunteer page that we had originally designed into our prototypes. We could not find a way to implement that into WordPress which made us resolve to using a normal standard form that we were satisfied with at the end. The second thing was the

color template. At the beginning we wanted to use the colors of the logo, emphasizing the color red into our design, but when we had our customer meeting Julius told us that a color like that might be too intense for a user of the website. Which is why we had to make changes in our WordPress design to include a color palette that was less intense and more welcoming for a user of OSICAN.

People-centred design ideas and final product

Many ideas and concepts discussed in the lectures did help us hinder our design exploration. Our knowledge of the people and the world were one of the reasons that allowed us to shine in many areas in our project. We understood the value of having this knowledge then translating it in different forms into our design. Our knowledge of the type of users we are to design for as well as the limitations and constraints of the tools at hand made it possible for us to produce our final product.

What we would do the same on future projects

As a collective, on future projects we could follow the same way when brainstorming as we did in this project. The process which made us come to the final product we have today was a result of many sessions of brainstorming, looking at other sites and designs that are similar which made us come to agreed conclusions. We believe in the near future of our engineering degrees, having strong methods in brainstorming is important and essential.

What we would do differently on future projects

Some of the things we could do differently in future projects is to generate more prototypes than what we had as a group. We believe each team member has an immense amount of ideas that are creative and functional and in order to bring that out, individual brainstorming needs to be completed. With that in mind, before finalizing our project we could have generated more prototypes for each person than what we originally had in this project. Instead of each person creating one low fidelity prototype, a better action would be to generate 3 low fidelity prototypes per person.

Opportunities and design ideas for future work

We believe we met most of the opportunities presented to us by the customer and solved most of the problems that the original website had and that the customer wanted to be changed and improved. We created an engaging, inviting and resourceful website which a user will be able to use and take great benefit from. We did not only work on creating an aesthetically pleasing design, but a function and purposeful one. Each element in our design had a purpose and a

solution to a problem. We believe this core concept of design which is to design for a purpose is an essential and crucial aspect of our engineering path, which we will carry with us as we go.

WordPress themes and plugins

Theme:

Item	Details
Theme Name	Astra
User Rating	4.9/5 Stars (6k+ ratings)
Last Updated	December, 2025
Active Installations	1+ million
What It Does	Astra is a fast, lightweight, and customizable WordPress theme. It works well with page builders and offers flexible layouts and ready-made templates for building any type of website and because of these features we used that for our website.

Plugins:

Item	Details
Plugin Name	Elementor
User Rating	4.5/5 Stars(7K+ ratings)
Last Updated	Dec, 2025
Active Installations	10+ million
What It Does	Elementor is a drag-and-drop page builder that makes it easy to design pages visually without coding. We used it to quickly create custom layouts and sections that match the site's design requirements.

Item	Details
Plugin Name	Ultimate Addons for Elementor Lite
User Rating	4.9/5 Stars(2K+ ratings)
Last Updated	Dec, 2025
Active Installations	2+ million
What It Does	The plugin adds extra widgets and design elements to enhance Elementor’s capabilities. We used it to create more advanced layouts and features that the core Elementor builder doesn’t include by default. For example for video slider we used that plugin.

Item	Details
Plugin Name	WPForms Lite
User Rating	4.8/5 Stars(13K+ ratings)
Last Updated	Nov, 2025
Active Installations	6+ million
What It Does	WPForms Lite is a beginner-friendly form builder for creating simple, drag-and-drop forms. We used it to build the volunteer form on the site quickly and easily.

Item	Details
Plugin Name	WPForms Lite
User Rating	4.8/5 Stars(13K+ ratings)
Last Updated	Nov, 2025
Active Installations	6+ million

What It Does	WPForms Lite is a beginner-friendly form builder for creating simple, drag-and-drop forms. We used it to build the volunteer form on the site quickly and easily.
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Item	Details
Plugin Name	BasePress
User Rating	4.8/5 Stars(70+ ratings)
Last Updated	Apr, 2025
Active Installations	2000+
What It Does	BasePress is a knowledge-base plugin used to organize and display resources clearly. We used it to create the Resources section so users can easily find helpful information.

Item	Details
Plugin Name	Theme Builder For Elementor
User Rating	4.0/5 Stars(4+ ratings)
Last Updated	Jul, 2025
Active Installations	2000+
What It Does	Theme Builder for Elementor lets you create custom layouts and

	structure parts of the site using Elementor. We used it to design specific layouts, then disabled it afterward, and we can re-enable it anytime if we need more layout changes.
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Image References

Non OSI-CAN Images

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A.I Generated Images

- Located on the home page: Image of person holding their head next to the title “What is PTSD”